Topic 8 — Sher Shah (शेरशाह) Suri

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Sher Shah Suri | Administration | Revenue Reforms | Road System | Currency Reforms | Military Reforms

Sources baked in: NCERT *Themes in Indian History Part II*, RS Sharma *Medieval India*, **Ghatnachakra** Babur–Sher Shah–Akbar chapters, UPPCS Prelims PYQs 2018–2025 **Weight:** ★★★ — Chausa/Kannauj, Jarib/Desai, Dam–Rupiya, Sasaram tomb order, Jayata–Kumpa Marwar **Last verified:** September 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A (purely historical)

8.1 Life, Rise, Reign

Farid Khan (c. 1472, **Sasaram**) | Father **Hasan Khan Sur** | Afghan **Sur**

Battle of Chausa (1539) — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Sher Shah challenged **Humayun's** fragile hold over the north after Afghan resistance revived in the east. **Course:** Armies met near **Chausa** on the **Ganga** (गंगा). Sher Shah used surprise and river tactics. Humayun escaped by swimming across the Ganga. **Result:** Mughal prestige collapsed in the east. **Kannauj/Bilgram (1540)** followed.

Battle of Kannauj / Bilgram (1540) — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Humayun tried to recover after Chausa. Sher Shah aimed for the Delhi throne. **Course:** Sher Shah defeated Humayun decisively at **Kannauj (Bilgram)**. **Result:** Humayun fled to **Iran (Safavid refuge)**. **Sher Shah** became ruler of north India (**1540–1545**).

- **Farid Khan** studied at **Jaunpur**, the **Siraj-i-Hind** centre, before Bihar service.
- In Bengal service he held the title **Hazrat-e-Ala**. After **Chausa (1539)** he took the imperial style **Sher Shah**.
- Before **Kannauj (1540)**, Sher Shah offered Humayun peace if he surrendered **Bihar** and **10 lakh** rupees but could keep **Bengal** — Humayun **declined**.
- **Qazi Fazilat** served as **Amin-i-Bengal**; Bengal was organised into **sirkars** under Sur rule.
- Sher Shah was born as **Farid Khan** around **1472** at **Sasaram**. His father was **Hasan Khan Sur**, an Afghan of the **Sur** clan.
- He served **Bahar Khan Lohani** in Bihar. Tradition says he killed a **tiger**, earning the title **Sher Khan**.
- After Bahar Khan's death, Sher Khan took **Bihar** and defeated Bengal's **Mahmud Shah**, building an eastern revenue base.
- He first cooperated with **Humayun** (हुमायूँ) against Bengal, then turned rival.
- At **Chausa on 26 June 1539** on the Ganga near Buxar (बक्सर), Sher Shah defeated Humayun. Humayun escaped on a **mashak** (inflated water-skin).

- At **Kannauj/Bilgram on 17 May 1540**, Sher Shah won decisively. Humayun fled through Sind (सिंध) into Persia and ceded Kandahar (कंधार) to the Safavids.
- Sher Shah took **Delhi** and assumed the title **Sher Shah Suri**. His Sur empire lasted **1540–1545**, only about five years, but left a lasting administrative legacy.
- Sher Shah died in **May 1545** during the siege of **Kalinjar** in Bundelkhand. A **gunpowder explosion** killed him; it was **not** a sword wound.
- His tomb is the lake mausoleum at **Sasaram (1545)** in Indo-Islamic (भारतीय-इस्लामी) style — after Atala Jaunpur and before Humayun's Tomb at Delhi (1565).
- His successor **Islam Shah (Jalal Khan)** ruled from **1545 to 1553**. The Sur empire then collapsed, and **Humayun returned in 1555**.
- **Todar Mal** served Sher Shah's revenue system before joining Akbar.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Humayun & Sur Battle Chronology (UPPCS / State PCS Master Spine):** - **1. Battle of Daurah (1532 CE):** Humayun defeated Afghan rebels led by Mahmud Lodi along the Gomti River (UP). - **2. Battle of Chausa (26 June 1539 CE):** Sher Shah routed Humayun near Buxar, Bihar; water-carrier (bhishti) **Nizam** saved Humayun's life; Sher Khan assumed royal title *Sher Shah*, read Khutba, and minted coins. - **3. Battle of Kannauj / Bilgram (17 May 1540 CE):** Decisive Sur victory forcing Humayun into 15-year exile and establishing the Second Afghan (Sur) Empire. - **4. Battle of Sirhind (22 June 1555 CE):** Humayun defeated the Sur forces, triumphantly recapturing Delhi and Agra. *(Distinction: Battle of Samugarh was in 1658 CE during Aurangzeb's war of succession).*

8.2 Administration

- Sher Shah ruled as sole sovereign. He did **not** create a hereditary mansab (मनसब) nobility like Akbar. He used spies (**barid**) to watch officers.
- Territory was divided into **Sarkar** (सरकार) (several parganas) and **Pargana** (परगना) (the basic admin-revenue unit).
- Each pargana had three key officers. The **Shiqdar** handled law, order, and local troops. The **Munshif** kept accounts and audited records. The **Amil** or **Desai** collected revenue.
- The **Khwan-i-Pargana** was the pargana record writer. The **Qazi** judged by sharia and stayed outside the revenue chain.
- At the sarkar level, **Shiqdar-i-Shiqdaran** and **Munshif-i-Munsifan** supervised the pargana officers.
- At the centre, **Diwan-i-Wazarat** managed finance, **Diwan-i-Ariz** handled army rolls and pay, and **Diwan-i-Risalat** dealt with grants and foreign affairs.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Sur Revenue Terminology & Apparatus (UPPCS Format):** - **Jarib:** Standard land-measuring rope/chain (made of hemp rope, later improved with iron rings under Akbar); strictly the measuring apparatus, **NOT a tax**. - **Jaribana:** Measurement fee / surveyor's charge (~2.5% of revenue). - **Muhasilana:** Tax collector's fee (~5% of revenue). - **Dam:** Standard

copper coin (380 grains). - **Desai / Deshmukh:** Hereditary local revenue collector/accountant at pargana level.

8.3 Revenue Reforms

- Sher Shah measured land first with the **jarib**, a bamboo rope fitted with **iron rings**, to fix a uniform **bigha**.
- Land was classified as **good**, **middle**, or **bad**. **Rai** was the cash rate of expected produce **per bigha**, set by crop and land class.
- **Zabt** fixed an annual **cash** demand on measured land. This became the template for Akbar's (अकबर) system under Todar Mal.
- The state issued a **patta** to the peasant showing area and demand. **Qabuliat** was the peasant's written acceptance.
- Amils collected revenue, munshifs audited accounts, and barid spies checked under-reporting.
- Sher Shah warned amils **not to crush peasants**, balancing income with stability.
- Akbar later added **dahsala** (दहसाला), a **10-year average** assessment, on top of this measurement base.

8.4 Road System

- Sher Shah built the **Sadak-e-Azam** (**Grand Trunk Road**) from **Sonargaon** in Bengal to **Peshawar/Kabul**, passing through the Patna (पटना)–Kannauj–Agra–Delhi corridor — a major UP axis.
- **Sarais** stood about every **12 kos** (roughly 20 miles), offering lodging, supplies, and security.
- **Kos-minars** marked distances along the road. A **dak** horse-post carried news quickly.
- Roads and forts let Sher Shah move troops against Humayun and Afghan rivals.
- Sher Shah rebuilt and fortified **Purana Qila** in Delhi. The mosque opposite it, **Khayr-ul-Manazil**, was built by **Maham Anaga** in Akbar's era, not by Sher Shah.

8.5 Currency Reforms

- Sher Shah standardised the **rupiya** in silver at about **178 grains**.
- The **dam** was the copper coin, worth about **1/40** of a rupiya.
- The **mohur** was the gold coin.
- He fixed weights and purity across mints at major towns.
- Akbar later regulated currency on the same lines; the chief copper coin remained the **Dam**.

[!TIP] **Exam Anchor — Currency System & Continuity (Sher Shah to Akbar):** - **Tri-metallic Innovation:** Sher Shah established the reformed trimetallic standard that became the basis for Mughal and later British Indian currency. - **Silver Rupee (रुपिया):** 178 grains weight (containing 173 grains pure silver). Inscribed with ruler's name, title, and mint in Arabic and Devanagari. - **Copper**

> **Dam (दाम):** 380 grains weight; daily currency of the masses. - **Official Exchange Ratio:** Under Sher Shah, **1 Silver Rupee = 64 Copper Dams (1 : 64)**. Under Akbar, the standardized revenue tariff was fixed at **40 Dams to 1 Rupee**.

8.6 Military Reforms

- Sher Shah used firearms and cannon. His death in a magazine blast at Kalinjar shows how central artillery had become.

Battle of Sammel / Giri-Sumel (1544) — Cause, Course, Result

Cause: Sher Shah needed to break **Rao Maldeo Rathore of Marwar**, whose rising power threatened Sur control of the western approaches after the Humayun wars.

Course: At **Sammel / Giri-Sumel in 1544**, Sher Shah used **forged letters** so Maldeo doubted his loyal Rathore captains **Jaita (Jayata)** and **Kumpa**. Maldeo withdrew, but the two Rathores stayed and died fighting.

Result: Sher Shah held the field, yet later said he nearly lost the **"empire of Hindustan for a handful of bajra (बाजरा)/millets." Jaita** and **Kumpa** remain Marwar Rathore martyr facts — not Mewar Sisodia captains.

- Key forts included **Rohtas in Bihar** (built against Humayun's return), **Chunar** (चुनार), **Kalinjar**, and **Ranthambhor**.
- Sher Shah maintained a standing force of cavalry, infantry, and elephants. Men were registered, and horses were branded with **dagh** — the precursor to the later Mughal chehra-dagh system.
- **Diwan-i-Ariz** was the central military office.

8.6 Master Fact-Locks — Humayun, Sur Administration & Mughal Architecture

Category / Entity	Specific Details & Exam Anchors	Historic Significance
Babur's Sons & Mothers	• **Humayun:** Eldest son, born 1508 in Kabul to **Maham Begum** (Shia lineage). • **Kamran & Askari:** Born to **Gulrukh Begum**. • **Hindal:** Born to **Dildar Begum**. • *Rao Jaitsi of Bikaner:* Kamran Mirza was defeated in the 1530s by **Rao Jaitsi** of Bikaner, celebrated in Beethu Souza's text *Rao-Jaitsi-Ro-Chhanda*.	Mughal dynastic origins

Category / Entity	Specific Details & Exam Anchors	Historic Significance
Humayun's Early Campaigns	• **Kalinjar Campaign (1531 CE)** • **First Siege of Chunar (1532 CE):** Humayun besieged Chunar Fort for 4 months until Sher Khan submitted. • **Raisina Fort (1532 CE):** Annexed by Humayun. • *Sur Negotiation:* Sher Khan offered to surrender Bihar and pay an annual tribute of 10 lakh dinars if allowed to retain Bengal; Humayun rejected the offer.	Early Mughal-Afghan rivalry
Bengal Administrative Restructuring	To prevent provincial insurrections, Sher Shah restructured Bengal into **19 Sirkars** (districts) under military Shiqdars, superintended by a civilian head titled **Amir-i-Bengal** (or *Amin-i-Bengal*). The renowned scholar **Qazi Fajilat** was the first appointed to this office. Across the rest of the empire, he instituted 47 Sirkars.	Administrative decentralization
Military Units of Islam Shah Suri	Sher Shah's successor **Islam Shah Suri** (ruled 1545–1553 CE) divided his imperial troops into standardized decimal-like units of **200, 250, and 500** soldiers, a structure later preserved by Sikandar Shah Suri.	Sur military reforms
Humayun's Tomb Architecture	Built at Delhi (1565–1572 CE) under the patronage of Humayun's senior widow **Haji Begum** (Bega Begum). Designed by the Persian architect **Mirak Mirza Ghiyas**. First mature **double-dome mausoleum** of Mughal architecture, set within a grand Persian Charbagh layout.	Precursor to the Taj Mahal